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Working Paper II



Rasika–Saṃskṛti–Saṃvāda

A Pedagogy of Offering and Reception in Nāṭya

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Comments and feedback are welcome.



॥ धर्मो विश्वस्य जगतः प्रतिष्ठा ॥

Dharma is the foundation of the entire universe.



Executive Summary

Nāṭya constitutes a relational aesthetic field in which *rasa* culminates in the responsive spectator. However, a structural imbalance marks the contemporary milieu: the refinement of performance without the cultivation of the *rasika*. Technical proficiency and performative opportunities have expanded, yet the conditions necessary for aesthetic reception have attenuated. Drawing on the *Nāṭyaśāstra*, particularly the principle of *sādhāraṇīkaraṇa*, the paper argues that *rasa* is co-realised through offering and cultivated reception. The aesthetic event thus remains incomplete without cultivated receptivity.

In response, it proposes a pedagogic reorientation articulated through a triadic framework: *rasika* (the receptive centre), *saṃskṛti* (culture as lived aesthetic environment), and *saṃvāda* (dialogue as method of transmission). This framework implies a pedagogic inversion from technique-led training to experience-led cultivation, where sensitivity precedes expression and perceptive capacity is cultivated alongside performative skill. *Saṃskṛti* is further understood as layered, requiring graded exposure from *deśī* immediacy to *mārga* refinement.

The paper contends that the cultivation of *rasikatva* is not ancillary but foundational. Where it declines, *nāṭya* risks shifting from an experiential art grounded in *rasa* to a form increasingly oriented toward spectacle; where it is restored, *nāṭya* regains its function as a vehicle of shared experience and cultural refinement. The argument thus situates aesthetic pedagogy within a broader civilisational concern, namely the formation of sensibility necessary for artistic vitality and the quality of public life.

An appendix further outlines a practical ‘*Rasa* Activation’ framework, identifying the distributed roles within the *sabhā* through which aesthetic co-realisation may be consciously supported and refined.

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I. The (Partly) Missing Rasika

The contemporary landscape of *nāṭya* presents a curious dissonance. Performances have multiplied in scale and frequency; festivals, showcases, and solo debuts now mark the cultural calendar. Technical proficiency has deepened, and access to training widened. Yet, alongside this visible flourishing, there is a less acknowledged thinning: the attenuation of attentive, responsive, and aesthetically engaged audiences.

This dissonance suggests that the challenge before the arts lies not in production, but in reception. This concern finds resonance in contemporary pedagogic reflections. Geeta Chandran has observed that arts education today remains largely performative and episodic, arguing that its aim should shift from producing performers to cultivating *rasikas*, individuals capable of aesthetic appreciation and inward engagement. The absence of such cultivation, she suggests, reflects not a lack of activity, but a misalignment in pedagogic intent.¹

For while *nāṭya* continues to be performed with rigour and dedication, the conditions necessary for *rasa* to arise are increasingly fragile. The *sabhā*, once imagined as a space of shared aesthetic experience, risks becoming a site of display where performance is witnessed, but not inwardly received.

This concern is echoed within the domain of performance itself. Navtej Johar has pointed to a growing lack of depth and meaning in performance,² while Anita Ratnam has cautioned against the reduction of classical dance to visual ‘eye-candy.’³ Taken together, these reflections point to a deeper reorientation from aesthetic experience toward spectacle.

¹ Geeta Chandran, “Arts Education Can Be Transformative When It Nurtures ‘Rasikas’ and Not Just Performers,” *The Indian Express*, September 3, 2025.

² “Q&A: Interest in Bharatanatyam Is on the Decline,” *The Times of India*, September 3, 2007, <https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/edit-page/qa-interest-in-bharatnatyam-is-on-the-decline/articleshow/2292794.cms>.

³ “Classical Dancers Are Eye Candies,” *The Times of India*, December 2, 2007, <https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/interviews/classical-dancers-are-eye-candies/articleshow/2595932.cms>.

If democracy may be understood as a form of *nāṭya*, a civilisational field in which harmony emerges through the evocation of *rasa*,⁴ then the attenuation of the *rasika* acquires wider significance. The *rasika* is not merely an aesthetic subject, but also a civic one. The diminishing capacity for aesthetic reception is thus not confined to the arts; it reflects a broader thinning of sensibility. A society that cannot receive *rasa* with depth and attentiveness may likewise struggle to sustain nuance, restraint, and shared understanding in its public life.

This paper begins from a simple but foundational claim: we are not facing a crisis of artistic production, but a crisis of aesthetic reception. The question is not merely how *nāṭya* is performed, but how it is received.

This requires a return to a principle central to the aesthetic tradition yet underemphasised in contemporary pedagogy: the centrality of the *rasika*. *Rasa* culminates in the inward experience of the responsive spectator. Without the *rasika*, the aesthetic process remains incomplete.

The cultivation of such a *rasika*, however, cannot be assumed. It must be formed through exposure, refinement, and dialogue. Where this formation is absent, *nāṭya* risks reorganising itself around visibility rather than experience, and around execution rather than evocation. The argument that follows proceeds from this premise: that without cultivated *rasikas*, the process remains incomplete.

II. The Culmination of Rasa: A Śāstraic Grounding

The claim that the aesthetic process remains incomplete without the *rasika* is not a modern reinterpretation, but is grounded in the classical theory of *nāṭya* itself. In the *Nāṭyaśāstra*, *rasa* is not conceived as a property residing solely within the performer, nor as an automatic outcome of technical execution. Rather, it is understood as a realised experience, one that emerges through a process culminating in the responsive spectator.

⁴ Rohit Viswanath, “Democracy as Nāṭya: Toward Civilisational Renewal,” *Narthaki*, January 15, 2026, <https://narthaki.com/info/articles/art581.html>.

Central to this understanding is the principle of *sādhāraṇīkaraṇa*, often described as the universalisation of emotion. Through the calibrated interplay of *bhāva*, *abhinaya*, and aesthetic suggestion, the particular is rendered universal, allowing the spectator to transcend the limitations of personal circumstance and enter a shared field of experience. What is presented on stage is not merely observed; it is inwardly relished (*āsvāda*), as the spectator recognises, resonates with, and ultimately inhabits the aesthetic state being evoked.⁵

This process shows that *rasa* is neither transmitted in a linear manner nor contained within the performance as an object, but unfolds through a relational movement across word, music, performance, and reception.⁶ This relational process may be understood as a dynamic of offering and reception: the performer prepares and offers aesthetic form, while the *rasika* receives and realises it. The performance provides structure and suggestion; through this act of offering, the conditions for *rasa* are made available for realisation in the *rasika*. *Rasa* is not produced but co-realised. The aesthetic event, therefore, is not complete at the point of expression; it culminates in reception.

Such a conception places the *rasika* at the centre of the aesthetic field. The spectator is not a passive recipient, but an active participant whose capacity for attention, sensitivity, and inward response determines the depth and quality of the experience. Without this cultivated responsiveness, the most refined expression may remain externally appreciated yet internally unfulfilled.

Classical commentators such as Abhinavagupta further emphasise that *rasa* is apprehended not as personal emotion, but as a distilled, contemplative experience. The spectator does not merely feel; he or she relishes (*rasayati*), entering a state that is at once affective and reflective.

It follows, then, that the aesthetic process presupposes a certain condition in the spectator. The emergence of *rasa* is contingent not only upon the integrity of

⁵ Padmaja Suresh, “The Role of Bhakti Bhava and Prema Bhava in Dance,” *Narthaki*, 2007, <https://narthaki.com/info/articles/art190.html>.

⁶ Padmaja Suresh, “The Shift From Shaivagama Tantra Tradition to Bharatanatyam in Modern Times,” paper presented at the Swadeshi Indology Conference, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wcEkwn-iWQc>

performance, but upon the presence of a receptive consciousness capable of participating in the act of universalisation. Where such receptivity is absent or underdeveloped, the process remains truncated: expression is delivered, but experience does not fully arise.

This *śāstraic* framework makes visible a dimension that contemporary practice often leaves implicit. If *rasa* culminates in the *rasika*, then the cultivation of this receptive capacity cannot be incidental. It must form an integral part of aesthetic training. To privilege performance while neglecting reception is to attend to only one half of the aesthetic equation.

The implications of this are significant. What appears today as a decline in depth or engagement is not merely a matter of changing tastes or external conditions; it reflects a structural imbalance within the aesthetic process itself. The question, therefore, is not only how *nāṭya* is to be performed, but how the conditions for its realisation are to be restored.

III. The Pedagogic Imbalance

If the deficit lies in reception, pedagogy must be reoriented. If the *śāstraic* framework locates the culmination of *rasa* in the *rasika*, then a critical question arises: how is this receptive capacity cultivated in contemporary practice?

A structural asymmetry becomes evident. While considerable attention is devoted to the training of performers, particularly the refinement of technique, precision of movement, and mastery of repertoire, the formation of the *rasika* remains largely unaddressed.

Pedagogy is predominantly oriented toward expression. This orientation has also been critically noted in contemporary discourse. As Geeta Chandran points out, institutional approaches to arts education often reduce engagement to performance-oriented outcomes, with limited scope for sustained aesthetic exposure. She emphasises that the experiential dimension, listening, observing,

and dwelling within artistic form, is frequently absent, thereby weakening the foundations of *rasikatva*.⁷

In this orientation, the *nartakī* is trained primarily as the locus of expression and offering, yet the corresponding cultivation of reception remains underdeveloped. Students are trained in *āṅgika* and *vācika abhinaya*, in *laya*, gesture, and alignment; they are prepared to present, to execute, and to perform. Far less emphasis is placed on the cultivation of perception.

Students may perform before they have learnt to observe with depth. The order of formation thus becomes inverted: expression is cultivated before perception.

This inversion may be clarified through a contrast between prevailing and reoriented pedagogic models:

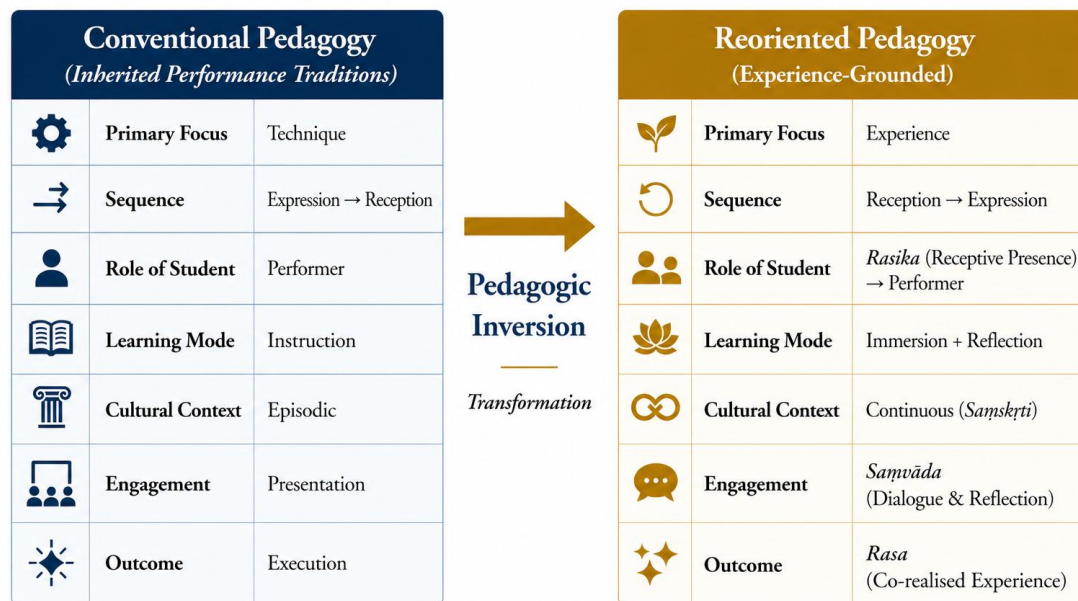


Figure 1. Pedagogic Inversion: From Technique-Led Training to Experience-Led Cultivation in *Nāṭya*

What is required, therefore, is not an abandonment of technique, but a reordering in which the cultivation of perception precedes and informs expression.

⁷ Chandran, “Arts Education Can Be Transformative.”

In contemporary reflections, this condition has also been described as a fragmentation in which only partial elements of a once integrated tradition persist.⁸ When pedagogy privileges execution over experience, the conditions necessary for *sādhāraṇīkaraṇa* are weakened. Expression becomes oriented toward display, while the inward dimension of *bhāva* diminishes.

This tendency is reinforced by an event-based cultural rhythm. Exposure is episodic rather than cumulative. Without sustained engagement, *rasikatva* does not mature.

The result is not a collapse of practice, but a reconfiguration of its centre of gravity. *Nāṭya* flourishes outwardly, while the relational space of *rasa* becomes attenuated. Expression is systematised; reception assumed. This does not diminish the demands placed upon the performer; it renders them more exacting as the locus of offering.

IV. Reorienting Pedagogy

If the imbalance within contemporary practice arises from the neglect of reception, then the task before pedagogy is not merely corrective but fundamentally reorienting. The cultivation of the *rasika* must move from implicit assumption to explicit aim. This requires not an abandonment of existing methods, but their reordering within a broader aesthetic framework that recognises reception as foundational.

This reorientation takes the form of a triadic framework: *rasika*, *saṃskṛti*, and *saṃvāda*. Within this framework, the aesthetic process may be understood as involving offering and reception, where the *nartakī* mediates between *saṃskṛti* and *rasika* by articulating and offering form. These are interrelated dimensions of a single pedagogic movement from the formation of receptivity, through the embedding of culture, to the practice of reflective engagement.

This triadic relationship is schematically represented in figure 2 (on the following page):

⁸ Suresh, “Shift from Śaivāgama Tantra to Bharatanatyam.”

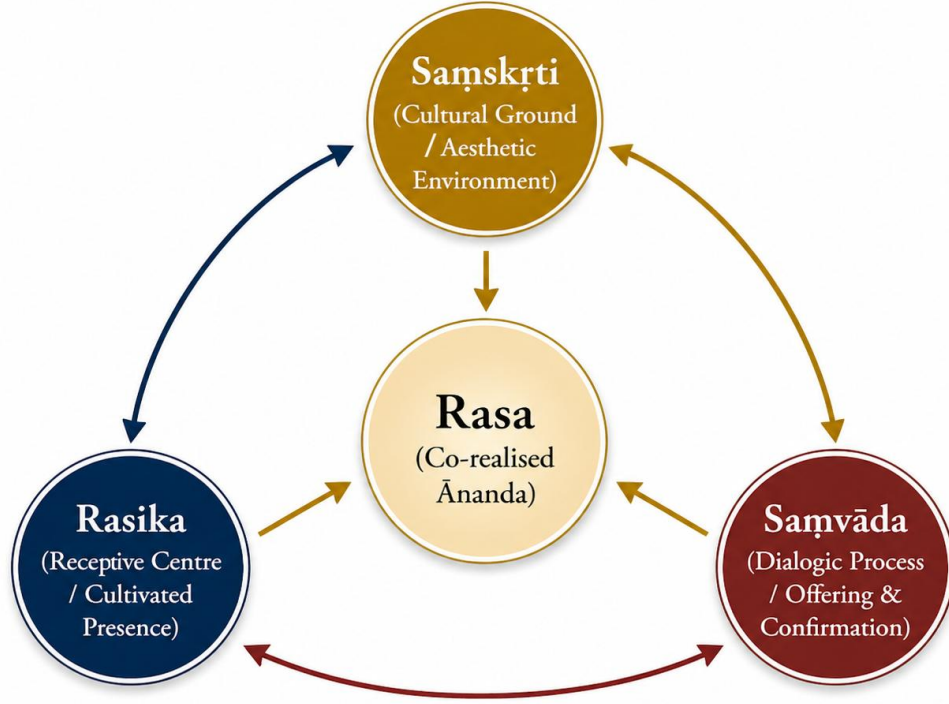


Figure 2. The *Rasika–Saṃskṛti–Saṃvāda* Triad:
A Relational Model of *Rasa* Co-Realisation

The diagram makes visible the relational nature of the aesthetic field, in which *rasa* is not located in any single element, but arises through their dynamic interplay.

1. Rasika: The Receptive Centre

To place the *rasika* at the centre is to recognise that the aesthetic process culminates not in performance, but in experience. This centrality does not diminish the role of the *nartakī*; rather, it renders her function more exacting as the mediator of aesthetic offering through whom the conditions for such experience are enabled. The *rasika* is an active participant in the unfolding of *rasa*, a receptive presence whose attention, sensitivity, and inward openness shape the very possibility of aesthetic realisation.

The cultivation of such receptivity cannot be incidental, but must be consciously fostered. This aligns with the view that aesthetic education must begin not with performance, but with exposure and experience. The ability to sit with sound,

observe performance, and internalise *bhāva* forms the basis from which deeper engagement arises. Without this preparatory ground, the transition from perception to expression remains incomplete.⁹

Such cultivation involves practices that refine perception: attentive viewing, sustained listening, and the gradual deepening of aesthetic awareness. It requires learning to dwell within the unfolding of a performance, to register nuance, and to allow suggestion to resonate without haste.

The formation of the *rasika* thus precedes and accompanies the training of the performer. The ability to receive with depth becomes the ground upon which meaningful expression can arise. Without this ground, technique, however refined, risks remaining externally oriented: precise in execution, yet limited in evocation. The *nartakī*, therefore, does not contain *rasa*, but enables its articulation, serving as the medium through which aesthetic possibility is offered into the shared field of experience.

2. *Samskṛti*: Culture as Lived Aesthetic Rhythm

If receptivity is to be cultivated, it must be situated within a sustaining environment. *Samskṛti*, in this context, is not an abstract inheritance nor an occasional event, but a lived, daily rhythm of aesthetic exposure. It is through repeated and varied encounters with sound, movement, gesture, and narrative that sensitivity is gradually refined.

Such a rhythm cannot be confined to formal instruction or periodic performance. It must extend into the texture of everyday life: listening to music beyond the demands of practice, observing performances without the pressure to reproduce them, and allowing aesthetic impressions to accumulate over time. Through this continuity, the capacity for sustained attention and inward response is formed.

Samskṛti, however, is not uniform. It unfolds across levels, ranging from the immediacy of *deśī* forms, rooted in familiarity and shared context, to the refinement of *mārga* traditions, characterised by abstraction and universality.

⁹ Chandran, “Arts Education Can Be Transformative.”

This movement may be broadly likened to the progression from dialect to *Prākṛta* to *Samskṛta*, not as a hierarchy of value, but as a gradation of articulation and depth.

Rasikatva matures through this very passage. The familiar provides entry; the refined invites extension; the universal sustains contemplation. To bypass this movement is to risk either superficial accessibility or inaccessible abstraction. A pedagogy attentive to *samskṛti* therefore recognises the need for graded exposure, where immediacy and refinement are not opposed, but sequentially integrated.

3. Saṃvāda: Dialogue as Transmission

If *samskṛti* provides the environment, *saṃvāda* offers the method through which experience is clarified and deepened. Aesthetic understanding does not arise solely through solitary exposure; it is shaped and refined through shared reflection. Dialogue between teacher and student, among peers, and within the *sabhā* becomes a vital medium of transmission.

Such dialogue need not be formal or discursive in a narrow sense. It may take the form of guided viewing, where attention is directed toward particular aspects of a performance; reflective conversation, where impressions are articulated and examined; or comparative engagement, where different interpretations are considered. Through these processes, the initial encounter with a work is revisited, deepened, and integrated.

Saṃvāda thus transforms reception from a fleeting experience into a sustained inquiry. It also serves as a mode of confirmation, through which aesthetic experience is recognised, shared, and inwardly affirmed. It enables the movement from immediate response to reflective appreciation, from impression to insight. In doing so, it cultivates not only sensitivity, but discernment, the capacity to recognise depth, to distinguish nuance, and to engage with aesthetic form in a considered manner.

V. Implications: From Aesthetic Experience to Cultural and Public Life

The re-centering of the *rasika* within *nāṭya* pedagogy carries implications that extend beyond the domain of performance. If *rasa* is realised through cultivated reception, aesthetic experience extends into cultural and public life. The formation of *rasikatva*, in this sense, is not only an artistic concern; it is a civilisational one.

A sustained engagement with aesthetic form refines perception. Through repeated exposure, reflection, and dialogue, the *rasika* develops an attentiveness that moves beyond immediacy toward nuance, extending into habits of listening, interpretation, and participation in shared spaces.

Where such capacities are cultivated, cultural life acquires depth. A sustained culture of aesthetic discourse accompanies this cultivation, enabling reflection, articulation, and continuity beyond isolated performance events. Artistic expression is met with responsiveness rather than mere consumption; performances become occasions for shared experience rather than isolated display. The *sabhā*, in turn, regains its character as a space of collective attunement, where meaning is not only presented, but co-realised.

Conversely, where *rasikatva* remains underdeveloped, the effects become evident. Art risks being approached as spectacle: appreciated for its surface qualities yet disengaged from its deeper resonances. Cultural participation becomes episodic, oriented around events rather than sustained engagement. The capacity for aesthetic experience, lacking reinforcement, gradually attenuates.

This attenuation extends into public life as well. If, as suggested earlier, civic spaces may be understood through the lens of *nāṭya*, then the ability to receive with attentiveness and respond with discernment becomes integral to their functioning. A society that cannot sustain aesthetic attention may find it difficult to sustain nuance in discourse, restraint in expression, or shared understanding across difference.

The cultivation of *rasikas* thus contributes, in a consequential manner, to the shaping of public sensibility. It fosters dispositions that support not only artistic vitality, but also the quality of collective life. The question of pedagogy thus extends beyond institutions into the wider cultural fabric, including publication platforms, spaces of dialogue, and sustained engagement through workshops, seminars, and festivals.

To recognise this is not to expand the scope of *nāṭya* indiscriminately, but to acknowledge its inherent orientation. As envisioned in the classical tradition, *nāṭya* was never confined to performance alone; it functioned as a medium through which experience was refined and shared. To restore this function is to restore a dimension of culture that reconnects aesthetic practice with lived life.

VI. Conclusion: Restoration, Not Reform

This paper has sought to identify and address a structural imbalance within contemporary *nāṭya* practice: the refinement of expression without a corresponding cultivation of reception. While performance has been systematised and sustained with dedication, the formation of the *rasika* has remained largely implicit. The result is not an absence of activity, but a thinning of the conditions necessary for *rasa* to arise.

Returning to the *śāstraic* understanding makes clear that this imbalance is not inherent to the tradition, but a departure from it. If *rasa* culminates in the *rasika*, then the cultivation of receptive capacity is integral to the aesthetic process. To attend to one without the other is to leave that process incomplete.

The proposed reorientation, articulated through the framework of *rasika-saṃskṛti-saṃvāda*, does not seek to displace existing practices, but to reorder them. By situating experience prior to technique, and reception alongside expression, it restores balance to the pedagogic field. The aim is not to diminish performance, but to deepen the conditions from which meaningful performance can emerge.

The implications of this shift extend beyond the arts. Where *rasikatva* declines, art risks becoming display, and culture an episodic occurrence. Where it is cultivated, *nāṭya* regains its function as a vehicle of shared experience, one that refines perception and sustains a rhythm of engagement within society. The *sabhā*, in such a context, becomes once again a space of collective attunement rather than mere observation.

The future of *nāṭya*, therefore, does not lie solely in the continued training of performers, but in the parallel cultivation of a culture capable of receiving what is performed. The task ahead is not only to refine practice, but to cultivate the conditions through which it may be received, discussed, and sustained. This is not a call for reform in the narrow sense, but for the restoration of a relational understanding in which offering and reception are held in balance.

In this light, the question with which the paper began may be restated: not only how *nāṭya* is to be performed, but how it is to be experienced. For it is in this experience, shared, sustained, and refined, that *rasa* arises, and through it, the deeper continuity of aesthetic and cultural life is maintained.

Appendix: Toward a Rasa Activation Framework in Practice

While the preceding discussion has sought to establish the co-realisation of *rasa* as a relational aesthetic process grounded in the interplay of offering and reception, a further question arises at the level of practice: how may the conditions for such co-realisation be consciously enabled within the contemporary *sabhā*?

The challenge is not merely one of performance, but of activation. If *rasa* depends upon the presence of a receptive and responsive *rasika*, then the aesthetic field must be gently prepared, guided, and attuned. This appendix outlines a provisional framework through which such activation may be approached, without reducing the aesthetic experience to prescription.

1. Framing the Aesthetic Field

Prior to performance, the role of the guru or *sabhā* organiser assumes significance in preparing the ground of reception. This may take the form of a brief and sensitive orientation, drawing attention to the aesthetic dimensions of the items to follow, not as explanation, but as invitation.

Such framing does not seek to instruct the *rasika* in what to feel, but to attune attention. It situates the performance within an aesthetic horizon, enabling the spectator to enter the unfolding experience with a heightened awareness of *bhāva* and its possible transformations into *rasa*.

2. Mediating the Aesthetic Movement

Within the performance itself, the compere may serve as a subtle mediator between offering and reception. By gently indicating the dominant *bhāva* or *rasa* associated with each item, the compere provides a thread of continuity through which the audience may orient its perception.

This function is not didactic, but facilitative. It does not replace the spectator's experience, but supports it, particularly in contexts where familiarity with the repertoire or its aesthetic codes may be limited. In this sense, the compere participates in the transmission of *saṃskṛti* by sustaining the intelligibility of the aesthetic form.

3. Attuning to Reception: Signals of Rasa

The co-realisation of *rasa* is not complete without attention to the responses it evokes. These responses are not merely internal or ineffable; they often find expression, subtle or pronounced, in the embodied and affective responses of the audience.

The importance of such responsiveness is not merely a contemporary concern, but finds clear articulation in the classical tradition. In the *Nāṭyaśāstra*, Bharata describes a range of audience responses corresponding to the successful evocation of particular emotional states: smiles in response to delineated emotion, laughter to humour, exclamations of appreciation to virtuous

expression, and tears or sighs in moments of pathos.¹⁰ These responses are not incidental, but indicative of aesthetic participation. They suggest that the realisation of *rasa* is accompanied by discernible shifts in the spectator's embodied and expressive state, making reception at once inward and outwardly perceptible.

Classical commentators deepen this understanding further. Abhinavagupta emphasises that *rasa* is realised as a contemplative and transformative experience within the spectator.¹¹ The responses described by Bharata may thus be understood as outward correlates of this inward aesthetic absorption described earlier. Reception, in this sense, is both experiential and manifest: inwardly realised, yet outwardly traceable in gesture, voice, and affect.

To recognise such signals requires sensitivity on the part of all participants, the performer, organiser, and mediator alike. Where these signals are perceived, they may be gently amplified through pacing, emphasis, or modulation. Where they are weak or attenuated, they invite reflection. In this way, reception becomes not merely an outcome, but a source of insight into the unfolding aesthetic process.

4. Toward a Responsive Aesthetic Ecology

Taken together, these elements suggest that the *sabhā* may be understood not simply as a venue of presentation, but as a responsive aesthetic ecology. Within this ecology, the realisation of *rasa* depends upon a distributed attentiveness: the guru or organiser prepares the field, the performer offers form, the compere sustains orientation, and the *rasika* receives and realises.

Such a framework does not seek to formalise or regulate aesthetic experience. Rather, it acknowledges that the conditions for *rasa* may be consciously nurtured. In doing so, it extends the pedagogic concern of the paper into the domain of practice, where the cultivation of *rasikatva* finds its immediate field of application.

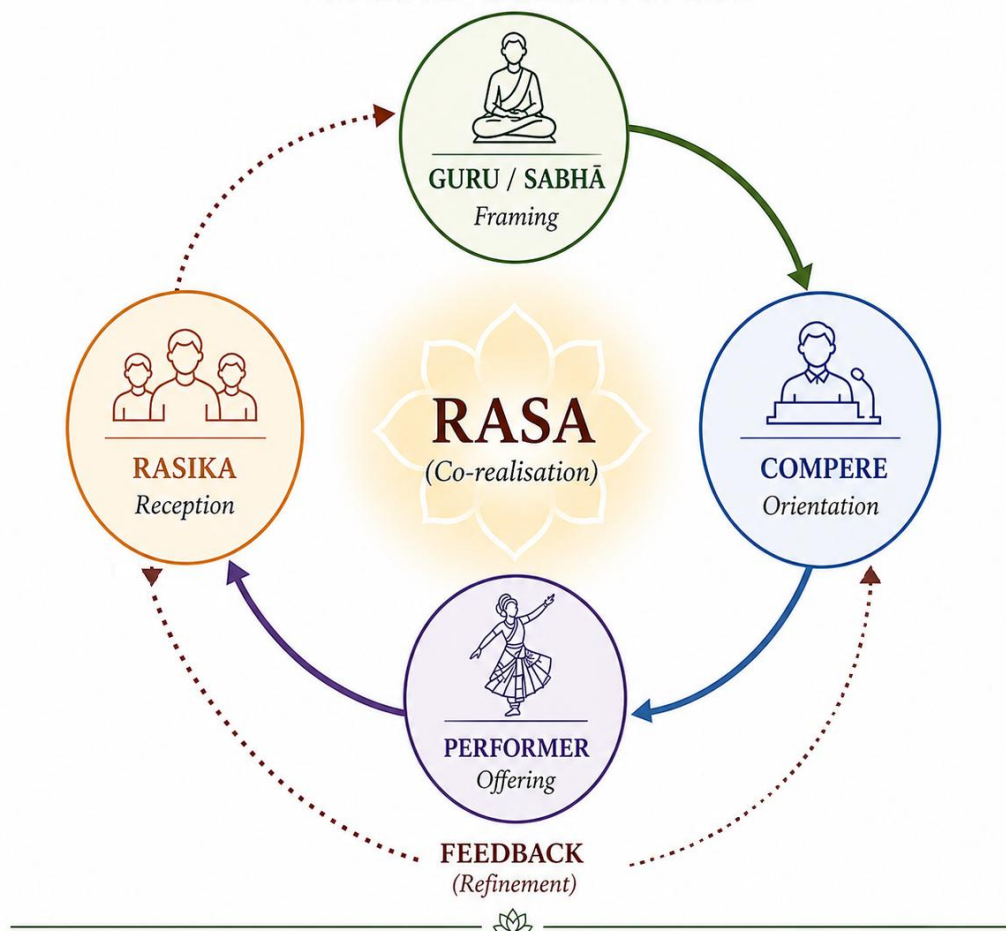
¹⁰ Bharata Muni, *Nāṭyaśāstra*, trans. Manomohan Ghosh (Calcutta: Asiatic Society, 1951–1967).

¹¹ Abhinavagupta, *Abhinavabhāratī* (commentary on the *Nāṭyaśāstra*), in *The Nāṭyaśāstra of Bharata Muni*, trans. Manomohan Ghosh (Calcutta: Asiatic Society, 1951–1967).

The distributed process of *rasa* activation within the *sabhā* may be schematically represented as follows:

Figure 3: **RASA ACTIVATION LOOP**

Aesthetic Co-realisation in the Sabhā



A schematic representation of the distributed processes of framing, orientation, offering, and reception—through which *rasa* is co-realised within the *sabhā*, with feedback enabling continuous refinement.
